

wider ATM access—important if you make a lot of cash deposits.

- **What will it cost to use ATMs?** Check the bank's ATM policy. Find out if you can use its ATM network. If you can't, or if the bank doesn't have one, this could add up to hefty surcharges. Some Internet banks may credit you automatically for ATM surcharges, while others may require you to mail in your ATM receipts in order to get reimbursed, which can be a pain. Some may not credit you at all.
- **Will you need to write paper checks?** While some Internet-only banks have begun to issue checkbooks and debit cards, most of them provide electronic bill-paying services. This can be convenient in many situations, but not when you need to give someone a check right away.
- **How much time does it take for a check to clear?** Internet banks sometimes take *longer* to process checks than traditional banks. You may have to wait as long as five business days after the bank receives your check to see the funds in your account. If your online bank doesn't have ATMs that allow you to make a deposit, this could mean a week on top of the length of time your check is in the mail.
- **Will you miss speaking with a bank teller?** Truth is, I don't know anyone other than my dad who regularly speaks to a teller. But if you're so inclined, customer service at an Internet bank is sometimes limited to phone calls and e-mails. Even if your Internet bank is affiliated with a brick and mortar bank, you won't be able to walk into a branch office and consult tellers.

↓ WHAT TO DO WITH YOUR SAVINGS

No matter what kind of bank you use, bank savings options don't offer the potential for phenomenal gains, but that's not what you're after here. When it comes to savings, safety and access—not phenomenal returns—are the